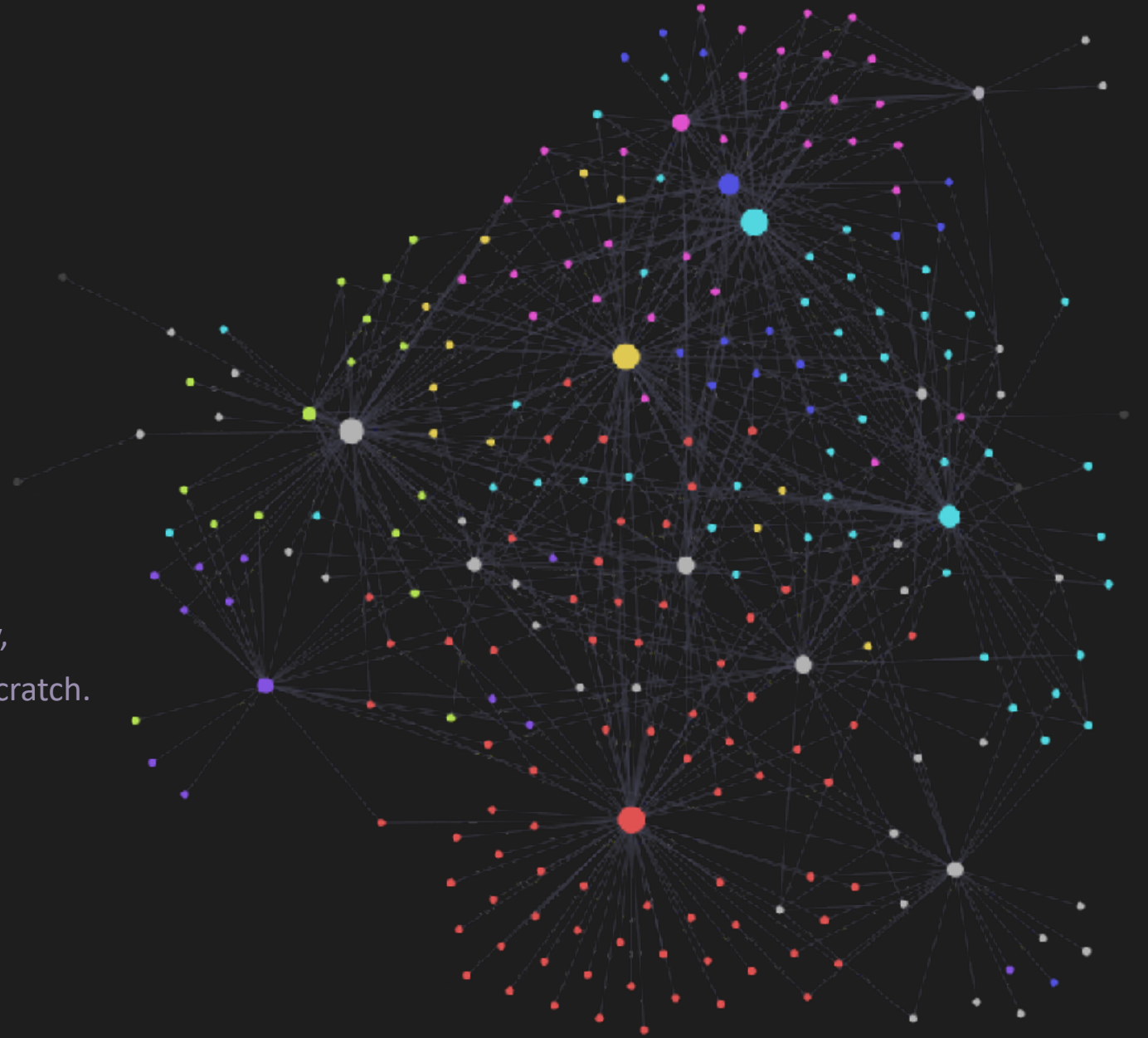


A BEGINNER'S GUIDE

Obsidian

A note-taking tool for research, science, bibliography,
and project & task management — explained from scratch.

PLAIN-TEXT NOTES • LOCAL FILES • LINKED THINKING



What is Obsidian?

Obsidian is a free app for taking notes as plain-text Markdown files, stored locally on your computer. Instead of folders alone, you connect notes to each other with links — turning your notes into a personal, explorable web of ideas.



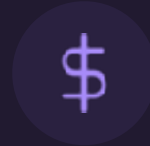
Markdown files

Notes are plain .md text files you fully own



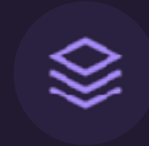
Your computer

Stored locally in a folder called a "vault"



Free to use

Core app is free; optional paid sync/publish



1000+ plugins

Extend it for almost any workflow

THE BUILDING BLOCKS



Vault

A folder on your computer holding all your notes. You can have several vaults for different areas of life.



Notes

Each note is a simple Markdown text file — readable in any text editor, forever, even without Obsidian.



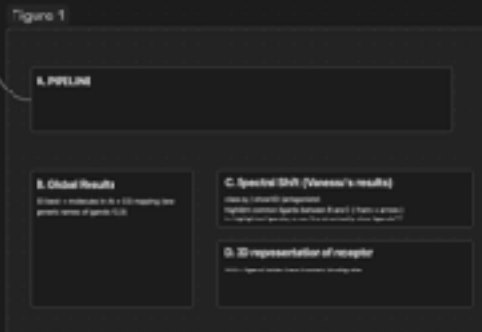
Graph view

A visual map of every note and link — patterns and connections you didn't know were there become visible.



Links [[]]

Type `[[note name]]` to connect two notes. Links can be created before the target note even exists.



Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



See backlinks automatically



Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly

The screenshot displays the Obsidian application interface. On the left is a sidebar with a file explorer and a list of tags. The main area shows a note titled 'Gutierrez-2019'. The note contains a title, a list of authors, a list of categories, and an abstract. The abstract text is: 'Giant unilamellar protein vesicles (GUPs) were formed with the adenosine A_{2A} receptor (A_{2A}R) incorporated in the lipid bilayer and protein partitioning into the liquid ordered and liquid disordered phases was observed. When no ligand is bound, A_{2A}R partitions preferentially into the liquid disordered phase of GUPs, while ligand-bound A_{2A}R partitions into the liquid ordered phase of GUPs. 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC), 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC) and cholesterol (Chol) using a detergent-assisted method'.

Below the abstract, there is a 'Commentary' section and a 'PDF' section. The PDF section shows a preview of the paper's title page, which includes the journal name 'ChemComm', the title 'The lipid phase preference of the adenosine A_{2A} receptor depends on its ligand binding state', and the authors 'M. Gertrude Gutierrez, Jacob Derrell, Ketz L. White, Lucie C. Dalle Ore, Vadim Chernozov, Raymond C. Stevens and Noah Melamed'.

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



See backlinks automatically



Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly

The screenshot displays the Obsidian application interface. The main note, titled "GPCRs", contains text about positive allosteric modulators (PAMs), negative allosteric modulators (NAMs), neutral allosteric ligands (NALs), biased allosteric modulators (BAMs), and orthosteric binding sites. It includes several references, such as "Chen-2020" and "Gutierrez-2019". The left sidebar shows a file explorer with a tree view of the vault's structure, including folders like "Bibliography" and "Categories". The right sidebar shows a search bar and a list of linked and unlinked mentions. A purple arrow points to the "Gutierrez-2019" reference in the main note, which is also listed in the "Linked mentions" section of the right sidebar.

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



See backlink



Zoom out with



Full-text search

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



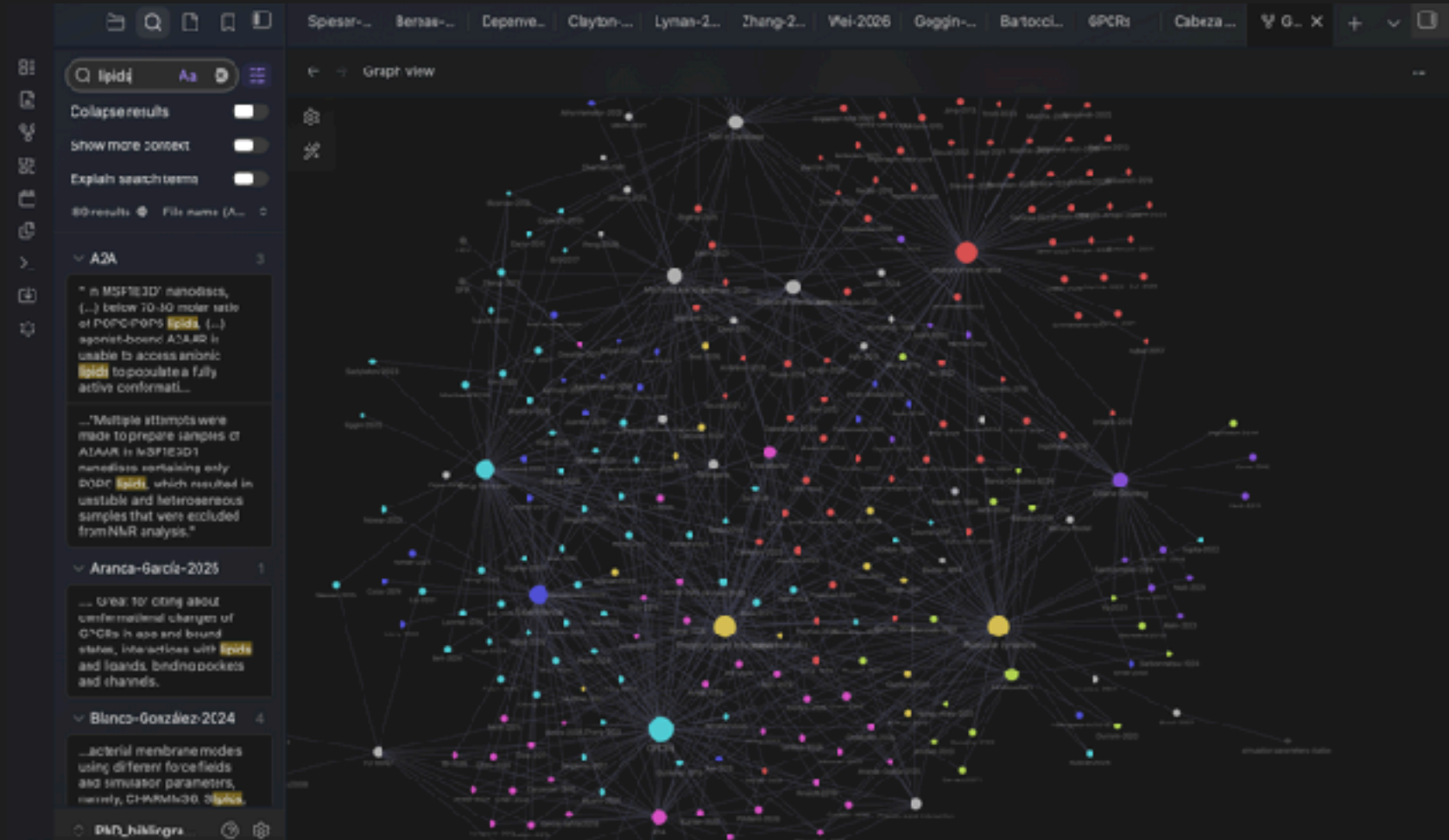
See backlinks automatically



Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly



Time management

Daily notes



One note per day, created automatically from a template : journal, log, or planner.

Calendar view



See a month at a glance and jump straight into any day's note.

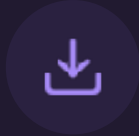
Templates



Pre-fill each day with goals, a task list, planned experiments and meetings

Getting started, step by step

1

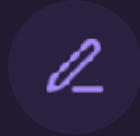


Install & open

Download Obsidian (free) for your computer or phone and create a new vault — just a folder.



2

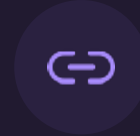


Write your first notes

Start plainly: one note per topic, paper, or day. Don't worry about structure yet.



3



Start linking

As ideas repeat, connect them with `[[links]]`. Structure emerges from your notes, not before them.



4



Add a plugin

Once comfortable, add one plugin that solves a real need — Tasks, Calendar, or Citations.

Tip: don't over-plan folders and tags up front — a vault's structure works best when it grows from real use.

Pros



Free core app

Full note-taking features cost nothing; only sync/publish add-ons are paid.



You own your files

Plain Markdown files — no lock-in, no proprietary format, readable forever.



Works fully offline

No internet connection needed; everything lives on your device.



Deep customization

Community plugins and themes adapt it to almost any workflow.



Fast, local search

Instant full-text search across huge vaults, even with many PDFs attached.



Future-proof

Because notes are plain text, they'll open in any editor, decades from now.

Cons



Learning curve

Linking, plugins, and Markdown syntax take longer to learn than a simple notes app.



No built-in real-time collaboration

Not designed for co-editing a note live with others, unlike Notion or Google Docs.



Organization is on you

Few built-in rules — an unstructured vault can get messy without personal discipline.

IN SHORT

One tool, one vault, endless connections.

Obsidian trades built-in structure for flexibility and ownership: your notes, your files, your connections — useful for research, bibliography, tasks, and time, once you're willing to build the system yourself.

obsidian.md

